

Syllabus for “Advanced Introduction to Metaphysics”

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Introduction

Metaphysics is much too large and shapeless to attempt anything like a survey of the whole field in a semester. This course will not attempt that, but will focus on a smaller range of questions about *identity*, *necessity*, and *time* that have been pretty central to the literature since the 70s. I think that studying these questions will provide a good point of departure for a lot of other work in metaphysics, as well as for the metaphysical issues that tend to come up in other branches of philosophy.

My course catalog entry was a laundry list of rather dry-sounding questions relating to identity, necessity, and time that the course would cover. Here it is in the form of a numbered list, with some indication of when the questions will be discussed if we stick to the week-by-week schedule given below.

1. whether things can be identical but possibly distinct [Week 1]
2. whether things can be distinct but possibly identical [Week 4, Week 9]
3. whether things can be distinct but have all the same properties [Week 5]
4. whether things can be distinct but have all the same qualitative properties [Week 5]
5. whether every truth is necessitated by a qualitative truth [Week 3, Week 13]
6. whether propositions or properties can be distinct but necessarily equivalent [Week 8]
7. whether there are necessary truths that are not necessarily necessary [Week 7, Week 8]
8. whether there are truths that are not necessarily possible [Week 8]
9. whether there are things that could have not been identical to anything [Week 11]
10. whether there are certain respects (e.g. originating matter) in which objects could not be radically different from the way they in fact are [Weeks 6–10]
11. whether there are certain respects (e.g. originating matter) in which objects could not be even slightly different from the way they in fact are [Weeks 6–10]
12. whether objects can coincide with (be in exactly the same place as, or be made of exactly the same matter as) objects distinct from themselves [Weeks 1–4]
13. how many objects coincide with any given object, and in what respects they differ [Week 4, Week 10]
14. whether objects can permanently, or necessarily, coincide with objects distinct from themselves [Weeks 1–4]
15. whether there are any temporary truths [Week 12]
16. whether there are temporary necessary truths [not sure]

17. whether there are any temporary qualitative truths [Week 13]
18. whether there are any contingent qualitative truths [Week 13]

Readings

To get a lot of the course, you'll need to devote a fair amount of time to reading. Certain weeks will be structured around a discussion of one particular reading, and really won't make sense unless you've done that reading. For other weeks, I will list suggested readings, but I won't presuppose that anyone has read any particular thing. Often, the best strategy would be to start by skimming a number of papers and then choose one or more of them to read carefully in whole or in part, based on what seems interesting and worthwhile.

I am close to finishing a book, *How Different Could Things Be?* (coauthored with John Hawthorne and Juhani Yli-Vakkuri), which covers many of the topics of the seminar and does not presuppose any specific background knowledge. I will make this available to the class, and for some meetings I will use it to structure our discussion. It will be updated over the course of the semester.

Week-by-week list of topics and readings

Readings marked ★ will be the main focus of the class. Readings marked * are introductory surveys (e.g. handbook articles) which cover similar ground to the class. Readings marked ♦ are "background" and will probably not directly discussed in class.

1. Leibniz's Law, coincidence, and the necessity of identity.
 - * Ofra Magidor, 'Leibniz's Law Arguments in Metaphysics'
 - Saul Kripke, 'Identity and Necessity'
 - Judith Jarvis Thomson, 'The Statue and the Clay'
2. Doubts about de re modality
 - Willard van Orman Quine, 'Reference and Modality'
 - Allan Gibbard, 'Contingent Identity'
 - ♦ Ruth Barcan (later Ruth Barcan Marcus), 'A Functional Calculus of First Order Based on Strict Implication'.
3. Counterpart theory
 - David Lewis, 'Counterpart Theory and Quantified Modal Logic'
 - David Lewis, 'Counterparts of Persons And Their Bodies'
 - Delia Graff Fara, 'Relative Sameness Counterpart Theory'
4. More on coincidence versus monism
 - ★ Kit Fine, 'The Non-Identity of a Material Thing and Its Matter'.
 - Kit Fine, 'A Counterexample to Locke's Thesis'

- Karen Bennett, 'Spatio-Temporal Coincidence and the Grounding Problem'
 - HDCTB, chapter 3
- 5. Identity of indiscernibles; qualitateness; anti-haecceitism
 - ★ Robert Merrihew Adams, 'Primitive Thisness and Primitive Identity'
- 6. Tolerance Puzzles
 - Hugh S. Chandler, 'Plantinga and the Contingently Possible' (5 pp.)
 - HDCTB, chapters 1 and 2
 - Nathan Salmon, *Reference and Essence*, Appendix IV
 - * Teresa Robertson, 'Modal Paradox'.
 - ❖ Roderick Chisholm, 'Identity through Possible Worlds: Some Questions'
- 7. Sufficiency principles, origin essentialism, and hypertolerance
 - Saul Kripke, *Naming and Necessity*, lecture 3, up to footnote 56.
 - HDCTB, chapters 4 and 5
 - Nathan Salmon, *Reference and Essence*, chapter 7
 - Teresa Robertson, 'Possibilities and the Arguments for Origin Essentialism'
 - Penelope Mackie, *How Things Might Have Been*.
- 8. Iteration-denial and higher order identity
 - HDCTB, chapter 0 (sections 1–3), chapter 6
- 9. Iteration-denial and the nature of metaphysical necessity
 - HDCTB, chapter 7
 - Justin Clarke-Doane, 'Metaphysical and Absolute Possibility'
 - Andrew Bacon, 'The Broadest Necessity'
- 10. Plenitude
 - HDCTB, chapter 10
 - Maegan Fairchild and John Hawthorne, 'Against Conservatism in Metaphysics'
 - Kit Fine, 'A Thing and its Parts'
 - * Maegan Fairchild, 'Varieties of Plenitude'
- 11. Necessitism and contingentism
 - Timothy Williamson, *Modal Logic as Metaphysics*, chapter 1
 - Jeremy Goodman, 'An Argument for Necessitism'
- 12. The A-theory / B-theory debate
 - Dean Zimmerman, 'The A-theory of Time, the B-theory of Time, and "Taking Tense Seriously"'.
 - Daniel Deasy, 'The Moving Spotlight Theory'
- 13. Temporal counterpart theory
 - Ted Sider, 'All The World's a Stage'
 - Ted Sider, 'The Stage View and Temporary Intrinsics'

- Sarah Moss, 'Four-Dimensionalist Theories of Persistence'
14. Overflow.